otherwise carefully measured statements that tended to evoke constitutional principles as an acid test for minority protections. Now Jinnah asserted that lasting harmony between communities could not be established in ‘a Court of Law’ or through a constitution ‘however perfect from a theoretical point of view it may seem’.[34] Instead, it could only turn into a reality through ‘the highest order of statesmanship and political wisdom’ and the recognition that ‘there is no progress for India until the Musalmans and Hindus are united’.[35] The alternative Jinnah presciently predicted was ‘a revolution and civil war’.[36]

When Jinnah re-emerged on the political scene in 1934, after an extended hiatus to heal from the humiliation in the aftermath of the Nehru Report, he began to filter politics more squarely through the lens of war and peace. In his earliest engagements to uphold Muslim rights upon his return, Jinnah ventured to arbitrate the Shahidganj dispute. In this dispute, Lahori Muslims demanded that the local Sikh community return a former mosque to them that had since been used as a Sikh shrine.[37] While hearing both sides and establishing a joint Sikh-Muslim committee to investigate this conflict further, Jinnah did not resolve the dispute. But it was the first move away from his earlier politics. He had begun to embrace religious symbolism to further the politics of the Muslim League. Contractual arrangements that he had long championed were in Jinnah’s eyes now inherently flimsy and ‘always subject to alteration by the nation’.[38] Jinnah was not just referring to the Shahidganj dispute but the broader communal problem in India when he contended that for such issues, the law was insufficient to ‘work out an honourable settlement’.[39]

Moving from contractual obligations to honour was reflective of Jinnah’s changed perspective. Earlier, he had viewed Indian Muslims primarily as a minority community, constantly vying to petition for rights from the British crown or the Congress party. Now he saw Indian Muslims as a distinct and separate nation capable of ensuring their rights through force. This view clashed severely with the secularist outlook of Jawaharlal Nehru, who could only interpret Jinnah’s religious posturing as a profound symptom of